

19 Jacob

The schemer who wrestled with God, limped away blessed, and gave his new name, Israel, to a nation.

Jacob was born grasping his twin brother's heel, and for much of his life he kept grasping. He bought Esau's birthright and stole his father's blessing, then ran for his life. On the road God met him in a dream and promised never to leave him. In Haran the deceiver was himself deceived by Laban. Coming home, he wrestled through the night and would not let go without a blessing. He left with a limp and a new name, Israel, and his twelve sons became the twelve tribes. "The God of Jacob" gives hope to every flawed believer.

At a glance

Name	Jacob, "supplanter" (Genesis 27:36); renamed Israel
Family	Twin of Esau; wives Leah and Rachel; twelve sons, Dinah
When	Traditionally c. 2006–1859 BC; many scholars c. 2000–1700 BC
Key places	Bethel, Haran, Peniel, Shechem, Hebron, Goshen
Key people	Isaac, Rebekah, Esau, Laban, Leah, Rachel, Joseph
Lifespan	147 years (Genesis 47:28)
Main passages	Genesis 25:19–35:29; 37; 42–50
New Testament	John 1:51; 4:5–12; Romans 9:10–13; Hebrews 11:21

"And he said, Thy name shall be called no more Jacob, but Israel: for as a prince hast thou power with God and with men, and hast prevailed."

Genesis 32:28, KJV

The life of Jacob

Ages come from Genesis. The traditional chronology (from 1 Kings 6:1) has Jacob entering Egypt c. 1876 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

Isaac age 60	●	Born second Jacob is born holding Esau's heel and grows up "a plain man, dwelling in tents." <i>Genesis 25:21–27</i>
Isaac old and blind	●	Takes the blessing In Esau's clothes Jacob says, "I am Esau thy firstborn." Esau vows to kill him, and Jacob flees. <i>Genesis 27:1–28:5</i>
On the road	●	Dreams at Bethel He sees a ladder to heaven. God renews Abraham's promises: "I am with thee." Jacob makes a vow. <i>Genesis 28:10–22</i>
In Haran	●	Twenty years with Laban Given Leah instead of Rachel, he serves fourteen years for his wives and six for flocks. <i>Genesis 29:1–31:55</i>
At the Jabbok	●	Wrestles and is renamed Alone at night, he wrestles a man until dawn and is renamed Israel. Esau embraces him. <i>Genesis 32:1–33:17</i>
Back in Canaan	●	Loses Rachel and Joseph Rachel dies bearing Benjamin. His sons sell Joseph, and Jacob refuses to be comforted. <i>Genesis 35:16–20; 37:2–35</i>
Age 130	●	Goes down to Egypt God says, "Fear not to go down into Egypt." Jacob stands before Pharaoh and blesses him. <i>Genesis 45:25–47:10</i>
Age 147	●	Blesses his sons and dies He blesses Joseph's sons and his twelve sons, and is buried at Machpelah. <i>Genesis 47:28–50:13</i>

Key activities

The man who wrestled Jacob is not named. Jacob says he has "seen God face to face" (Genesis 32:30), and Hosea 12:4 calls him "the angel." Many Christians see this as an appearance of God in human form; others see an angel sent by God.

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- I Bought the birthright.** He made hungry Esau swear it away for bread and lentil stew. *Genesis 25:29–34*

 - 2 Deceived his father.** He lied three times, even saying, "The LORD thy God brought it to me." *Genesis 27:18–29*

 - 3 Made a vow at Bethel.** He promised that the LORD would be his God and pledged a tenth of all God gave him. *Genesis 28:16–22*

 - 4 Served for love.** His seven years for Rachel "seemed unto him but a few days, for the love he had to her." *Genesis 29:18–20*

 - 5 Was deceived himself.** On the wedding night Laban gave him Leah instead of Rachel. *Genesis 29:21–30*

 - 6 Fathered twelve sons.** Through Leah, Rachel, Bilhah and Zilpah, amid bitter rivalry between the sisters, the family of Israel was born. *Genesis 29:31–30:24; 35:16–18*

 - 7 Prospered under pressure.** Though Laban changed his wages ten times, God made him rich. *Genesis 30:25–43; 31:38–42*

 - 8 Prayed in fear.** "I am not worthy of the least of all the mercies." *Genesis 32:9–12*

 - 9 Wrestled for a blessing.** "I will not let thee go, except thou bless me." He limped away renamed Israel. *Genesis 32:24–32*

 - 10 Returned to Bethel.** He told his household to put away their foreign gods and built an altar where God had first met him. *Genesis 35:1–15*

 - 11 Favored Joseph.** He loved Joseph most and gave him a coat of many colours, which stirred his brothers' hatred. *Genesis 37:3–4*

 - 12 Blessed by faith.** Dying, he blessed Joseph's sons and spoke over each of his own sons. *Genesis 48:1–49:33; Hebrews 11:21*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jacob.

Old Testament

Genesis 25–50	The main account of his life
Deuteronomy 26:5	"A Syrian ready to perish was my father," most take as Jacob
Psalms 46:7	"The God of Jacob is our refuge"
Hosea 12:3–4, 12	He took his brother by the heel, wept and prayed

New Testament

Matthew 8:11	He will sit with Abraham and Isaac in the kingdom
John 1:51	"Angels of God ascending and descending upon the Son of man"
John 4:5–12	Jesus sits at "Jacob's well"
Romans 9:10–13	God chose Jacob before the twins were born
Hebrews 11:21	He blessed Joseph's sons and "worshipped"
Echo: 2 Corinthians 12:9	Strength made perfect in weakness

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God promise Jacob at Bethel, though he was running from his own wrongdoing (Genesis 28:13–15)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God let Jacob walk away with a limp?
3. *Apply:* "I will not let thee go, except thou bless me." What should you keep praying about?
4. *Apply:* Jacob repeated his parents' favoritism. What family pattern do you want to stop with you?